

Optasia (OPA.JSE)

Channel VAS Investments Limited — the near-pure-play of MNO-embedded nano-lending, at a full-fintech multiple on a frontier-EM earnings base.

Sector: Consumer Finance · Fintech · Listing: JSE Prime Segment (4 Nov 2025) · Reference price: R16.91 · As-of: 7 June 2026

WATCH — DO NOT INITIATE

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RECOMMENDATION

WATCH — Do Not Initiate

Two independent gates point the same way. First, a hard governance gate: Chronos Capital is a 29.1% shareholder and a named selling shareholder in the March-2026 FirstRand block trade, and a Spock principal sits on the Optasia board. Any position is a related-party action requiring recusal and external review before it can be contemplated

[Red Flags — Chronos conflict; Investor Sentiment — ownership].

Second, on the merits and independent of the conflict, the price is wrong. At R16.91 the screen sits ~18% above the probability-weighted fair value of ~R13.90 and ~27% above the DCF base of R12.40 *[Valuation — pricing read]*.

A genuinely interesting frontier-fintech franchise at a full-fintech multiple on a frontier-EM earnings base. The doctrine answer for an asymmetric thesis at the wrong price is WATCH, not STARTER.

STRATEGY VERDICT

RECOMMENDATION

WATCH

INITIAL SIZE

MARGIN OF SAFETY

STARTER BAND

Below ~R12.00

None (gated
twice)

~-18% blended
/ ~-27% DCF
base

The asymmetry is real; the entry point is not here. No position at entry — both because of the conflict gate and because base-case IRR is negative at the current price. If the Chronos conflict were resolved (recusal + independent mandate), the merits answer would still be WATCH until the price falls into the starter band below ~R12.00, or until disclosure closes the disintermediation gap (contractual MNO tenure / take-rate durability) and a country-level revenue table.

\$265.4m

FY2025 REVENUE
(+75.5%)

63%

MFS SHARE OF
REVENUE (+149%)

43.2%

ADJ EBITDA MARGIN
(FROM 49.7%)

1.2%

BLENDED DEFAULT
RATE

31.6x

P/E REPORTED (~24X
NORMALISED)

-12%

PROBABILITY-
WEIGHTED IRR

§1 — EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Optasia is the near-pure-play of the MNO-embedded nano-lending archetype: a non-bank credit platform plugged into mobile-network operators' billing and wallet rails, extending very-small-ticket, very-short-tenor unsecured advances to prepaid subscribers. It is the dominant incumbent in airtime-credit advance (ACS) plus the faster-growing micro-finance-solutions (MFS) leg, with no close-scale public listed peer globally

[AI Unit Economics; Competitor Analysis]. The operator owns distribution, the customer relationship and the data; Optasia supplies credit decisioning, working-capital funding, and absorbs subscriber default risk through financial-guarantee contracts and ECL provisioning.

The AI is the operating substrate, not a bolt-on. The credit decision is an AI decision: real-time scoring on ~5,000 data elements, 100+ models, ~1.5bn credit decisions per month and ~64bn since 2016, at ~32m loan transactions per day. Holding a 1.2% blended loss rate while scaling micro-lending +149% is the single strongest piece of evidence the engine works

[AI Unit Economics — verdict]. The Tool User Gate passes at grade B; the deployment reaches AI

maturity Level 4 (full automation, no human-in-loop per loan) but stops short of Level 5 because attribution is narrative-plus-headline-KPI rather than cohort-causal.

FY2025 (year-end 31 December 2025, E&Y unmodified opinion) delivered revenue of \$265.4m (+75.5%), with MFS at \$167.5m (+149%, now 63% of revenue) and ACS at \$96.9m (+17.4%); adjusted EBITDA of \$114.5m at a 43.2% margin (down from 49.7%); reported net income \$43.1m and normalised \$57.8m (+57%) after ~\$23.4m of one-off IPO costs; blended take-rate up 4.0%→4.8%; default rate 1.2% *[Primary Filings — Note 6, P&L; Valuation]*. The thesis is asymmetric — a bull-bear IRR spread of ~54pp exceeds the 30pp doctrine target — but the entry price does not capture it.

The primary risk that must be managed is the iceberg: **MNO disintermediation**. The operator owns the customer, the wallet and the data; once it has watched years of repayment flow through Optasia's models, the marginal cost of in-housing the ~8% MFS take falls. Competitor Analysis cites Safaricom's Fuliza at 31.9% of NCBA pre-tax profit as the captive-bank precedent. Two further downside vectors converge — Nigeria FCCPC/DEON regulatory action against the airtime leg, and FX translation risk on a Nigeria/Ghana/DRC-weighted revenue base — and none is in the embedded price

[Competitor Analysis; Red Flags RF-REG-008; Valuation — reverse-DCF] (see §9).

The valuation verdict is FAIR-leaning-EXPENSIVE. P/E 31.6x reported / ~24x normalised; P/S 4.8x (~2x lending-platform median); EV/EBITDA ~13x — full-fintech multiples on a frontier-EM earnings base. The DCF base is R12.40; probability-weighted fair value ~R13.90 against the R16.91 screen, a negative margin of safety. The position-sizing recommendation is **no position**, gated twice: by the Chronos conflict (recusal pending) and by negative base-case IRR. The starter band is below ~R12.00; avoid above ~R17.00

[Valuation — pricing read; Red Flags — Chronos conflict] (see §7).

GATE-LEVEL CONFLICT NOTICE — CHRONOS RELATED-PARTY

Chronos Capital holds 29.1% of Optasia and was a named selling shareholder in the March-2026 FirstRand block trade; a Spock principal (Roger Grobler) has been a named Optasia board director since November 2022. This is an ADR-0012-class conflict-of-interest gate, not a fraud flag and not an investment objection. Any Chronos position is a related-party action requiring formal recusal of the conflicted director and an independent (non-Chronos) mandate / external review before the investment merits are even live. The human IC must rule on the recusal/independence question

against the Chronos T0 registry before proceeding

[Red Flags — Chronos conflict (ADR-0012 §5); Investor Sentiment — ownership].

§2 — COMPANY OVERVIEW

Channel VAS Investments Limited, trading as Optasia, is an AI-powered B2B2X fintech platform providing micro-financing solutions (MFS) and airtime credit solutions (ACS) to over 120 million active monthly users across 38 countries via 49 distribution partners

[Company History — overview]. The issuer is incorporated in the British Virgin Islands (co. no. 1750790), with financial HQ in Dubai (JLT) and operations centred in Athens, Greece. It listed on the JSE Prime Segment on 4 November 2025 at a R23.5bn market capitalisation (~\$1.3bn), with Standard Bank as JSE sponsor *[Primary Filings; Company History].*

Bassim Haidar — a Nigerian-born Lebanese entrepreneur who co-founded his first telecoms business, Intercomm Ltd, in 1991 — founded Channel VAS in December 2012 in Dubai to deliver micro and nano financial services to unbanked prepaid mobile subscribers in emerging markets *[Company History — T2, PR Newswire 24 Feb 2022; T2, Billionaires Africa 25 Apr 2026].* The original v1 model was an airtime-credit-advance product: a platform plugged into an MNO's billing rail, advancing tiny airtime amounts (~\$0.25) on 7-day terms and recovering repayment automatically on the subscriber's next top-up, at roughly 3% take rate. The company scaled this model across Africa, Asia and the Middle East through MNO revenue-share contracts, then layered the higher-take MFS nano-cash-loan leg on top.

The CEO is Salvador Anglada (appointed 2025), with 30+ years of international telecoms/fintech experience including CEO of e& enterprise (UAE), Group Chief Business Officer at e&, and over a decade at Telefonica including CEO of Telefonica O2 Czech Republic. The CFO is Mariusz Dabrowski (joined 2020). Founder Bassim Haidar remains a non-executive director. The group employs 356 people *[People & Culture — individual / team layer].*

The revenue model is a revenue-share toll: Optasia earns a take rate on the value advanced, blended up from 4.0% to 4.8% in FY2025 as the higher-take MFS leg (~8% MFS-level) outgrew the lower-take airtime leg (~3%). The loan book is the operating asset; ECL on financial-guarantee contracts feeds the P&L under IFRS 9, so credit risk is provisioned, not off-balance-sheet *[Primary Filings — MD&A drivers; AI Unit Economics].*

KEY METRIC (FY2025)	VALUE	FY2024	TIER
Revenue	\$265.4m	\$151.2m	[T1 — Primary Filings Note 6]
Revenue growth YoY	+75.5%	—	[T1 — Primary Filings]
MFS revenue	\$167.5m	\$67.3m	[T1 — Primary Filings Note 6]
ACS revenue	\$96.9m	\$82.5m	[T1 — Primary Filings Note 6]
Adjusted EBITDA	\$114.5m	—	[T2 — Valuation]
Adjusted EBITDA margin	43.2%	49.7%	[T2 — Valuation]
Reported net income	\$43.1m	\$36.2m	[T1 — Primary Filings P&L]
Normalised net income	\$57.8m	—	[T2 — Valuation]
Blended take rate	4.8%	4.0%	[T1 — Primary Filings MD&A]
Default rate	1.2%	0.9%	[T1 — Primary Filings MD&A]
Total service users	432m	+43%	[T2 — Earnings Transcripts]

Franchise quality indexes above the consumer-finance median on growth and credit performance; the open question is durability, not the current run-rate.

§3 — MARKET OPPORTUNITY

Optasia monetises the friction of prepaid airtime top-ups and the credit-starvation of unbanked frontier subscribers. The MFS leg distributes nano-cash loans (FY2025 nano-loans facilitated of \$2,301.3m, up from \$967.9m) while the ACS leg advances airtime (\$3,176.3m advanced, up from \$2,829.2m) [T1 — Primary Filings Note 6]. Platform value distributed reached \$5.5bn (+44%) in FY2025 [Earnings Transcripts; AI Unit Economics]. The opportunity is the formal-credit gap across a frontier footprint with single-digit banking penetration and fast-scaling mobile-money rails.

The headroom is real but geographically concentrated. The country layers read Nigeria at maximal headroom (135) but Red-band realisability (CRI 68), and DRC at high headroom (128) but Black-band realisability (CRI 44) — the large-opportunity / low-realisability pattern the two-score architecture exists to surface. Ghana (CRI 90, headroom 118), Tanzania

(89/115), South Africa (103/132) and Benin (101/124, the CFA-peg outlier) round out the named footprint *[Country layers — Ghana / Nigeria / DRC / Tanzania / SA / Benin × Consumer Finance]*.

The penetration thesis rests on two structural advantages: a 13-year proprietary frontier-credit dataset (~121m monthly active users, ~300 scoring decisions per second) that a new entrant cannot replicate on a 2–3 year horizon, and deep billing/USSD/mobile-money integration that FNB Equity Insights calls "complex and costly" to switch away from

[Competitor Analysis — moat assessment, T2 FNB Equity Insights Oct 2025]. FY2025 growth came from eight new MFS deployments (Cameroon, Ghana, Congo-Brazzaville) and ACS into Liberia, Eswatini and Malaysia *[T1 — Primary Filings MD&A]*.

TAM CAVEAT

No independent McKinsey/BCG/Bain TAM/SAM/SOM sizing was sourced for this run; the market-opportunity read is built from disclosed volume metrics and the country-layer headroom indices, not a third-party analyst market-size estimate. Treat the addressable-market framing as *[unverifiable]* on the top-down sizing axis.

Headroom indexes well above median across the footprint; realisability is the binding constraint, not opportunity size.

§4 — COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Optasia occupies an unusual position: it is the dominant incumbent in MNO-embedded nano-lending with no close-scale public listed peer globally. The operating peer set is mostly private or sub-scale, and the most dangerous "competitor" is the MNO partner itself

[Competitor Analysis — operating peer set, T3 FNB Equity Insights / Tracxn 2026].

COMPETITOR	TYPE	STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES	THREAT
JUMO (ZA/London, private)	AI-native	~\$304m raised; \$8.7bn loans to 35m customers; July-2025 Orange Money partnership replicating the MNO-rails model	Private; no listed scale benchmark	HIGH
Bemobi / Tiaxa (BMOB3.SA, listed)	AI-native	Nearest by archetype — nano-credit via MNO CDR data	LatAm / SE-Asia concentration, limited Africa overlap	MED

COMPETITOR	TYPE	STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES	THREAT
Juvo (US/Brazil, private)	AI-native	Financial-identity layer	Brazil-focused; identity not direct underwriting; limited Africa	LOW
In-house MNO captives (Fuliza/M-Shwari, MTN XtraTime)	Platform / incumbent	Own the customer, wallet, billing rail and data; Fuliza = 31.9% of NCBA pre-tax profit	Build cost / multi-year delay to replicate cross-MNO model	HIGH
Simbrella, Kuunda, Airvantage, Ezra	AI-native	Regional niche platforms	None approaches Optasia's scale	LOW

Moat assessment (Helmer 7 Powers). The operative powers are *Cornered Resource* and *Switching Costs*. Scale Economies score 1 (32m loan transactions/day driving cost-per-decision below any challenger), with the false-positive test partially triggered — EBITDA margin compressed from 49.7% (FY24) to 45.9% (1H25) during the growth surge, reflecting working-capital scaling rather than unit-economic deterioration. Counter-Positioning scores 2 (the MNO cannot replicate a cross-MNO, cross-country model without cannibalising its regulatory and operational core). Switching Costs score 1; Cornered Resource scores 1 (the 13-year dataset + the Ghana Fintech Licence, April 2024, as a near-term exclusion-value asset). Branding, Network Economies and Process Power all score 0 at current stage. Weighted score: 5/14 — **medium-moat, not wide**; moat_index 115 relative to the operating peer set [*Competitor Analysis — moat assessment*].

Moat durability and the platform-risk question. The dataset and integration are not replicable by a well-funded AI-native attacker on a 2–3 year horizon — but the durability question is not about an external attacker. It is whether the ~8% MFS take survives the operator in-housing the credit decision once it has watched years of repayment data flow through Optasia's models. That is the Fuliza/NCBA captive-bank precedent, and it is the single power that the MNO's structural ability to in-house directly counters

[*Competitor Analysis; Strategy — helmer_7_powers*].

COMPETITIVE VERDICT — MODERATE (MEDIUM-MOAT)

The franchise is the scaled incumbent with a genuine data-and-integration moat, but it is medium-moat (5/14), not wide. The binding competitive threat is disintermediation

by the very counterparty that supplies distribution — the iceberg in \$9 — not head-to-head competition from JUMO or the sub-scale regional set.

Moat index 115 vs the operating peer set — above median, but the operative power is structurally counter-positioned by the MNO's in-housing option.

§5 — MANAGEMENT TEAM

CEO — Salvador Anglada (appointed 2025). The strongest individual in the coverage set: 30+ years of international telecoms/fintech leadership (e& enterprise CEO, e& Group Chief Business Officer for 8 years, Telefonica O2 Czech Republic CEO, over a decade at Telefonica). His repertoire — large-scale operator strategy, enterprise carve-outs, M&A execution — maps directly to Optasia's MNO-partnership model and geographic-expansion agenda. AI orientation is STRATEGIC. One identifiable courage episode: accepting the CEO role at a founder-dominated-governance company and leading the IPO in a challenging macro environment. Integrity gate: clear *[People & Culture — individual layer]*.

ROLE	NAME	TENURE	NOTE
CEO	Salvador Anglada	2025	e&/Telefonica pedigree; top-tier role fit
CFO	Mariusz Dabrowski	2020	25+ yrs finance ops; stable pre-IPO tenure
Founder / NED	Bassim Haidar	2012	Built business to IPO; founder-shadow governance watch
Independent Chair	Michael Jordaan	Apr 2025	Ex-FNB CEO 2004–2013, Bank Zero co-founder
CPO	(appointed 2026)	2026	Role thin/unfilled through IPO — see culture layer

Board and governance signal. Independent Chair Michael Jordaan (former FNB CEO, Bank Zero co-founder) is split from the CEO. FirstRand's stake (20% at IPO, 26.1% by March 2026) is the most important external-endorsement signal in the file — South Africa's second-largest banking group increasing its position within four months of listing is a credible institutional-quality endorsement *[People & Culture — individual layer]*.

Bench depth — THIN. Only one name per function is publicly named; succession planning for CEO, CFO and CTO is not visible in public sources, attaching single-point-of-failure flags to all three. Shared C-suite tenure is "fresh" (median under 24 months); the CEO joined 2025, the CPO 2026, with only CFO (2020) and CDO on multi-year tenure. Seven of the current directors joined within the last three years, confirming the freshness and creating a board learning-curve risk on the AI platform and EM credit-cycle dynamics

[People & Culture — team layer].

Culture — bimodal. Glassdoor: 85 reviews (clearing the 75-review medium-high-confidence threshold), aggregate 3.1/5.0, recommend-to-friend 51%, positive business outlook 49%. Positive reviews cite good compensation, international environment and interesting technical work; negative reviews consistently surface management favouritism, silos, absence of operational structure and senior-management disrespect — a pattern consistent across years, suggesting structural rather than episodic middle-management dysfunction. The 2026 CPO appointment is a direct operational response, a positive signal that also confirms the prior deficiency *[People & Culture — culture layer].*

PEOPLE VERDICT — CAPABLE TOP, THIN BENCH, PROVISIONAL READ

Key-person risk: HIGH. Execution capability: top-tier at the CEO seat, untested as a team through a full credit cycle or FX-stress event. Founder Bassim Haidar's dual role as founder/NED/probable large shareholder alongside the externally-appointed CEO is a governance-concentration watch-flag (not a misconduct finding). The People & Culture verifier returned needs-revision; treat the individual-layer reads as provisional

[People & Culture — integrity gate; Strategy — people_provisional].

Leadership pedigree indexes above median; bench depth indexes below median. Net: a capable, freshly-assembled team carrying single-point-of-failure risk.

§6 — FINANCIAL SUMMARY

FY2025 (year-end 31 December 2025, E&Y Middle East unmodified opinion) is the company's first full year as a public issuer. Revenue grew +75.5% to \$265.4m, driven by MFS scaling +149% to \$167.5m (63% of revenue) while ACS grew +17.4% to \$96.9m. Adjusted EBITDA was \$114.5m at a 43.2% margin, down from 49.7% as the lower-take airtime/MFS mix scaled. Reported net income was \$43.1m (operating profit \$71.4m); normalised net

income was \$57.8m (+57%) after ~\$23.4m of one-off IPO costs

[T1 — Primary Filings Note 6, P&L; T2 — Valuation].

FINANCIALS (USD)	FY2024	FY2025	TIER
Revenue	\$151.2m	\$265.4m	[T1 — Primary Filings Note 6]
Operating profit	\$55.2m	\$71.4m	[T1 — Primary Filings P&L]
Adjusted EBITDA	—	\$114.5m	[T2 — Valuation]
Profit for the year (reported)	\$36.2m	\$43.1m	[T1 — Primary Filings P&L]
Normalised net income	—	\$57.8m	[T2 — Valuation]
Adjusted FCF	—	\$44.9m	[T2 — Valuation]
Total debt	—	\$106.8m	[T1 — Primary Filings]
Cash	—	\$94.0m	[T1 — Primary Filings]
Net debt / adj EBITDA	0.99x	0.11x	[T1 — Primary Filings]

Key observations. Net debt/adj EBITDA deleveraged sharply from 0.99x to 0.11x on the ~\$75m primary raise (net debt $\approx$ \$12.84m). Default rate ticked up to 1.2% (from 0.9%) with cover ratio (revenue $\div$ ECL provision) above 4x. FY2025 produced a net FX *gain* of \$4.25m (vs \$0.39m loss in 2024) from cedi/Congo-Brazzaville appreciation — meaning a chunk of USD-reported growth is currency translation, not local-currency volume. Working capital of \$107.2m equals 40.4% of revenue and is rising with MFS — a cash-absorption flag as the higher-ticket leg scales [T1 — Primary Filings MD&A].

Capital structure. Shares in issue 1,235,061,843 (par \$0.00004); IPO primary issuance of 68,486,843 shares for \$75.165m gross (\$60.7m net of \$14.4m costs). Basic/headline EPS 3.38 USD cents on a weighted 1,177,457,840 shares (the prior-year 772.09 cents on 46,663 shares reflects a 25,000:1 share split, not a performance signal). Fully-diluted share count is taken at ~1,236m [T1 — Primary Filings; inference — Valuation].

ACCOUNTING KEY AUDIT MATTERS — SURFACED, NOT GAAP DEPARTURES

(1) ECL on financial-guarantee contracts is the single Key Audit Matter (Note 12.3/25): provision \$33,248k (2024: \$22,378k), provision charge of the year \$65,209k — a highly judgemental, model-driven estimate on which the whole credit-risk

economics rest. (2) Revenue recognition is flagged as a KAM; the financial-guarantee fee is not priced separately from the credit-facilitation service. (3) The group recognises itself as *principal* in its revenue arrangements (Note 4) — directionally aggressive versus an agent/net presentation; warrants challenge. None are GAAP departures; all are surfaced for Red Flags / Valuation. Going concern is clean — no material-uncertainty or emphasis-of-matter paragraph

[T1 — Primary Filings — accounting red flags / going concern].

§6.1 — Capital Structure Stress Test

Stress 1 — operational shock (revenue compression). The bear scenario models a naira re-collapse plus an MNO contract loss. With net debt/adj EBITDA at just 0.11x post-raise, the balance sheet absorbs an operational shock comfortably on a leverage basis — the binding pressure is not covenant breach but the working-capital draw: at 40.4% of revenue and rising with MFS, a sharp MFS contraction would release working capital, while continued MFS growth into a revenue shock would compress free cash flow. The contingent exposure is the iceberg here: financial-guarantee credit exposure to MNOs/MFIs of \$317.9m (2024: \$213.3m), concentrated (top-5 "customers" = \$206m), plus off-balance-sheet bank guarantees of \$87.1m and margin deposits under lien of \$26.6m [T1 — Primary Filings Note 23].

Stress 2 — financing shock. Total debt is \$106.8m against \$94.0m cash; the post-IPO net-cash-light position and the 0.11x leverage materially de-risk the next refinancing window relative to the pre-IPO 0.99x. A financing-market shutdown would bite less on Optasia's own balance sheet than on its ability to fund loan-book growth — the equity cash that FCFE proxies at $\sim 0.80\times$ normalised net income is consumed by loan-book expansion, so a financing shock translates into a growth-rate cap rather than a solvency event

[T1 — Primary Filings; Valuation — DCF FCFE]. The Iraq litigation is a discrete tail: a subsidiary recovering $\approx \$9.5\text{m}$ receivable + \$2.3m guarantees faces a counterparty counter-claim of $\approx \$28\text{m}$; the receivable is fully provided, with no provision on the counter-claim (legal advice: likely to prevail) [T1 — Primary Filings Note 23].

Leverage indexes well below the consumer-finance median (0.11x); the off-balance-sheet guarantee book is the real stress vector, not on-balance-sheet debt.

Optasia is the near-pure-play MNO-embedded nano-lender; the loan book is the operating asset, so per the Chronos DCF Standard valuation routes to FCFE discounted at cost of equity, not UFCF at WACC (ECL already feeds the P&L under IFRS 9, so risk is not double-counted). The fair-value range is **R10.50 / R14.00 / R20.00** (low/base/high). Against the R16.91 screen, the base sits below the price: margin of safety is $\approx -27\%$ on the DCF base and $\approx -18\%$ on the probability-weighted blend. The stock is **FAIR-leaning-EXPENSIVE** — the IPO has already priced in the optimistic frontier-growth case *[Valuation — pricing read]*.

MULTIPLE (FULLY-DILUTED ~1,236M SHARES)	VALUE	VS MEDIAN (100)	VERDICT	TIER
P/E (reported EPS)	31.6x	135	stretched	<i>[T2 — Valuation, Simply Wall St]</i>
P/E (normalised NI \$57.8m)	~24.2x	110	stretched	<i>[inference — Valuation]</i>
EV/Revenue (P/S 4.8x)	~5.3x	130	stretched	<i>[inference — Valuation]</i>
EV/adj EBITDA	~13.2x	—	fair	<i>[inference — Valuation]</i>

P/S 4.8x is roughly 2x the ~2.5x lending-platform median but below AI-native infra (10x+) — the market is paying for the AI-scoring story, not the lending economics. Twelve-month price performance: listed 4 Nov 2025 at R19.00 IPO (opened R20.75); ~R16.91 by June 2026, i.e. $\sim -11\%$ versus IPO. Full 12-month history is unavailable on a sub-12-month listing

[T2 — Valuation, trading multiples].

§7.1 — Peer comparables

There is **no close-scale public listed peer** for the archetype. The valuation reference set is therefore a blended JSE/EM lending-fintech median (~2.5x P/S, ~24x P/E lower bound) with AI-native fintech infrastructure (10x+ P/S) as the upper bound. Peer-group quality: **WEAK** — Bemobi/Tiixa (BMOB3.SA) is the only listed archetype comparable and is LatAm/SE-Asia concentrated; the remaining direct competitors (JUMO, Juvo) are private

[Valuation — pricing read; Competitor Analysis — operating peer set].

§7.2 — Reverse Multiple Sanity Check

The reverse-DCF is the load-bearing finding. To justify R16.91 today you need EITHER ~30% near-term FCFE growth (above management's "low-to-mid twenties" guidance) at an 18% cost of equity, OR a ~15% cost of equity — i.e. pricing Optasia as a materially lower-country-risk entity than its Nigeria/Ghana/DRC-weighted revenue base supports. The market is

paying for the bull case. The MNO-disintermediation iceberg and the secular airtime-pool decline are **not** in the embedded price; they are downside the multiple has not discounted

[Valuation — reverse-DCF].

DCF BUILD (FCFE)

Cost of equity built component-by-component: US RFR $\sim 4.3\%$ + mature ERP $\sim 4.5\%$ (Damodaran 2026) + relevered beta ~ 1.3 + a revenue-weighted frontier country-risk premium $\sim 6.5\%$ (Damodaran 2026 CRP: Nigeria 10.0%, Ghana 12.0%, diversified across 38 markets, cross-checked against the country layers' geometric-mean CRIs) + $\sim 2\%$ small-cap/idiosyncratic premium $\rightarrow$ base $k_e \approx 18\%$. Two-stage: 22% near-term FCFE growth (management's "low-to-mid twenties" guidance) fading over five years to 5% terminal; FCFE proxied at $\sim 0.80\times$ normalised net income (loan-book growth consumes equity cash). **Base DCF $\approx$ R12.40/share; terminal value $\approx$ 40% of value**

[Valuation — DCF FCFE].

§7.3 — Scenario analysis (FCFE, 24-month horizon)

SCENARIO	PROB.	IMPLIED PRICE	IRR	ANCHOR
Bear	25%	R6.40	−39%	Naira re-collapse (Nigeria's $\sim 70\%$ 2022–24 FX move) + an MNO contract loss (Fuliza in-housing precedent)
Base	45%	R12.40	−14%	Guidance delivered, k_e holds
Bull	30%	R22.50	+15%	Kenya/Egypt/Indonesia expansion + multiple holds at IPO level

Probability-weighted fair value $\approx$ **R13.90**; bull-bear IRR spread **54pp** (exceeds the 30pp doctrine target). $\Sigma(p \times \text{IRR})$ blended $\approx -12\%$. The asymmetry is genuinely present, but it is skewed against the holder at the current price because the base case (p45) already sits below the screen [Valuation — scenarios; Strategy — power_law].

§7.4 — Bull- and bear-case IRR

The bull case (R22.50, p30) returns +15% IRR over a 24-month horizon on Kenya/Egypt/Indonesia expansion with the multiple held at IPO level. The bear case (R6.40, p25) returns **−39% IRR** on a naira re-collapse plus an MNO contract loss with multiple

compression. The base case (R12.40, p45) returns –14% IRR — guidance delivered, but the multiple lands base-case lower than today, not higher *[Valuation — scenarios; Strategy — pricing_view]*.

§7.5 — Exit Route & Precedent

The exit route for a re-rating thesis is open-market sale on a multiple re-rating, with a strategic-acquirer takeout as a secondary route — FirstRand's accumulation to 26.1% (and stated intent to integrate Optasia's credit-decisioning into bank-led channels) is the live strategic-acquirer signal in the file *[Investor Sentiment — ownership; activism]*. The condition for the open-market route is a naira/cedi stabilisation lifting USD translation plus disclosure closing the disintermediation gap; the condition for the strategic route is a control premium over a thin ~33% free float. No named comparable take-private/strategic precedent transaction at the implied multiple was sourced this run — flagged as a diligence gap.

§7.6 — Entry-price recommendation

ENTRY BANDS

Starter band: below ~R12.00 — where positive base-case IRR and a margin of safety are restored.

Avoid above: ~R17.00 — the screen at R16.91 sits ~18% above probability-weighted FV (R13.90) and ~27% above the DCF base (R12.40).

The multiple lands the base case *lower* than today, not higher. A name with an asymmetric thesis at the wrong price is a WATCH *[Valuation — entry band; Strategy — pricing]*.

Pricing indexes at ~70 vs median (FAIR-leaning-EXPENSIVE); the entry point, not the franchise, is what fails.

§8 — INVESTMENT THESIS

We believe Optasia is the scaled, AI-native incumbent of a real frontier-credit franchise — a 1.2% blended loss rate held while scaling micro-lending +149% is the operating proof that the scoring engine works, and the 13-year dataset plus deep billing-rail integration is a genuine medium-moat. **The market doesn't fully appreciate** that the embedded price already discounts the bull case: at R16.91 it requires ~30% growth (above guidance) or a ~15% cost of equity (too low for the country mix), leaving the MNO-disintermediation iceberg, the secular airtime-pool decline and the frontier-FX translation risk un-discounted.

We will be proven right when either the price falls into the starter band below ~R12.00 restoring positive base-case IRR, or disclosure closes the disintermediation gap (contractual MNO take-rate, contract tenure/renewal schedule, largest-MNO revenue concentration) — at which point the asymmetric thesis becomes investable rather than merely interesting.

§8.1 — Bull-Case Operational Constraints

1. HOLD THE MFS TAKE-RATE AS IT SCALES

Current state: blended take 4.0%→4.8%, but the gain is mix-shift (MFS to 63% of revenue), not an isolated AI lift. Required buildout: durable MFS-level take ~8% as volume grows. Execution risk: HIGH — disintermediation early-warning is precisely a take-rate erosion. Management track record: built the franchise to IPO, but the take has not been stress-tested through an operator renegotiation *[AI Unit Economics; Strategy — cltv_cac]*.

2. NEW LARGE-MNO PARTNER WINS OUTSIDE THE EXISTING BASE

Current state: 38 countries, 49 partners; FY2025 added eight MFS deployments. Required buildout: Kenya/Egypt/Indonesia-scale wins to deliver the bull case. Execution risk: MEDIUM-HIGH — the geographies most worth winning (Kenya) are where captive in-house models (Fuliza) already dominate. Management track record: the CEO's e&/Telefonica repertoire is directly applicable *[Valuation — scenarios; People & Culture]*.

3. CONVERT FRONTIER-FX STRENGTH INTO DURABLE USD TRANSLATION

Current state: FY2025 net FX gain \$4.25m from cedi/Congo-Brazzaville appreciation. Required buildout: naira/cedi stability sustained, not the engineered, reversible policy-induced strength the country layers flag. Execution risk: MEDIUM — outside management control; a country-level treasury overlay across 38 markets mitigates but does not remove it *[Primary Filings; Country layers]*.

§8.2 — Disconfirming Evidence

EVIDENCE AGAINST THE THESIS (HONEST SEARCH)

(1) The take-rate gain is mix-shift, not a causal AI lift — Tests 1–3 (break-point, cohort, decomposition) all return "not isolable from public disclosure," so the $\geq 9\times$ CLTV:CAC "exciting" bar cannot be evidenced *[AI Unit Economics; Strategy — cltv_cac]*. (2) Nigeria fell from ~50% to ~13.5% of revenue — presented as MFS growth, but it is a

structural deleveraging away from the highest-risk geography, not foregrounded as a strategic pivot *[Earnings Transcripts; AI Unit Economics — FX overlay]*. (3) The default rate *deteriorated* 0.9%→1.2% in the same release that headlines the take-rate gain; management does not foreground it *[Earnings Transcripts — KPI consistency]*. (4) The founder cut his stake ~21.6%→~1.5% within five months of listing, consuming a lock-up waiver — a governance/insider signal in tension with the FirstRand accumulation *[Investor Sentiment — insiders; Red Flags RF-RP-001]*. (5) Margin compressed 49.7%→43.2% adj EBITDA (net margin ~24%→15%) — mix-driven, but the direction is down *[Valuation; Red Flags]*. The disconfirming evidence is genuine and material; this is not a thesis with no bear.

The thesis indexes asymmetric-but-mispriced: bull-bear spread above doctrine target, probability-weighted IRR negative at the screen.

§9 — KEY RISKS & MITIGANTS

Red Flags fired 11 of 86 catalogue flags (8 high-severity), clustering in Related-Party, Regulatory and Founder-CEO categories; phase_2 is warranted, phase_3 is not *[Red Flags — pattern summary]*. The three load-bearing downside vectors converge and none is in the multiple.

THE BEAR CASE — MNO DISINTERMEDIATION IS THE ICEBERG

The operator owns the customer, the wallet and the data; Optasia supplies only the credit decisioning and the balance sheet. Once an MNO has watched years of repayment performance flow through Optasia's models, the marginal cost of in-housing the ~8% MFS take falls, and it captures the full take rather than sharing it. This is the most-proven dynamic in African mobile money: Safaricom's Fuliza/M-Shwari, run with NCBA and KCB as captive underwriting partners, generated ~31.9% of NCBA pre-tax profit in 2025. The 1.2% loss rate and the AI moat are necessary but not sufficient — the binding question is whether the take survives operators in-housing the decision. The valuation bear (R6.40, p25, IRR –39%) anchors to a naira re-collapse plus an MNO contract loss, and the reverse-DCF shows this downside is *not* in the embedded price

[Competitor Analysis — in-house MNO captives; AI Unit Economics — structural threat; Valuation — scenarios].

#	RISK	PROB.	IMPACT	MITIGANT	MONITORING TRIGGER
1	MNO disintermediation — single large-MNO in-houses or renegotiates the take	MED	HIGH	13-yr cross-MNO dataset + integration cost; multi-year captive-build delay	MFS take-rate flat or falling as it scales; loss of a named MNO contract
2	Nigeria FCCPC/DEON enforcement surviving the injunction	MED	MED	Federal High Court Abuja interim injunction in force; Nigeria now ~14% (from ~50%), the declining airtime leg	Injunction vacated; FCCPC enforcement resumes; MTN/Airtel Nigeria suspension
3	FX translation — naira/cedi reversal on engineered, reversible strength	MED	HIGH	Diversification across 38 markets; FY25 net FX gain \$4.25m	Cedi/naira depreciation; USD-reported take falling on stable local volume
4	Related-party cluster — founder exit (lock-up waived) + Finergi purchase at ~20x book	HIGH	MED	BDO fairness opinion; sale to strategic anchor (FirstRand), not open-market; full SENS disclosure	Further related-party transactions; additional lock-up waivers
5	Margin compression continuing as low-take airtime/MFS scales	HIGH	MED	Mix-shift, not manipulation; GAAP reconciliation provided	Adj EBITDA margin falling below ~43%; working capital above ~40% of revenue
6	Post-IPO lock-up unwind adding supply into a thin ~33% free float	MED	MED	Haidar overhang cleared cleanly to FirstRand at full price (R20), no price break	Further insider distribution; liquidity deterioration
7	Single-reportable-segment opacity — no MFS-vs-ACS profit split, no country revenue table	HIGH	MED	Revenue-line disaggregation (Note 6) provided; volume KPIs disclosed	Continued non-disclosure at FY2026; refusal of MNO-concentration schedule

NIGERIA REGULATORY — MATERIAL BUT CONTAINED

The FCCPC DEON regulations (effective Nov 2025) triggered a temporary suspension of airtime-credit via one MNO partner; a June-2026 Presidential directive names

Optasia directly; an interim High Court Abuja injunction restrains the FCCPC. Nigeria is ~14% of revenue and it is the declining airtime leg, not the MFS growth engine. Voice of Customer corroborates the regulator-mediated signal: predatory-collection and hidden-fee themes around the Nigerian subsidiary Nairatime are the most direct channel through which an MNO partner could justify terminating or re-pricing the relationship — MTN Nigeria and Airtel Nigeria were poised to suspend access before the injunction *[Red Flags RF-REG-008/001; Voice of Customer — Theme 1 / Theme 2]*.

DISCONFIRMING THE SCARY PATTERN — THIS IS NOT A FRAUD SIGNAL

The related-party cluster echoes founder-monetisation-at-listing, NOT a Wirecard/Tingo accounting-fraud pattern. The auditor is E&Y (Big-4) with an unmodified opinion; there is no restatement and no scope limitation; the CFO has been stable since 2020; the independent Chair (Michael Jordaan) is split from the CEO (Salvador Anglada); FirstRand is a 26.1% strategic anchor. The Wirecard/Tingo cash-and-auditor auto-escalation does NOT fire

[Red Flags — disconfirming the scary pattern; Primary Filings — going concern].

§9.X — Bear Source Search Log

DOCUMENTED BEAR-SOURCE SEARCH

Sources searched: JSE SENS substantial-holder and director-dealings record; sell-side coverage (the two covering analysts — James Starke, Morgan Stanley; Nadim Mohamed, SBG Securities); investigative journalism on the Nigerian subsidiary (FCCPC press, SocietyReporters, Billionaires Africa); regulator enforcement files (FCCPC DEON). **Named bear voices found:** no published structured short thesis and no named short-seller report — JSE does not publish issuer-level short interest, so the short side is unobservable. The closest to a bear is the regulator: the FCCPC's DEON action and the June-2026 Presidential directive naming Optasia constitute a state-level adversarial position on the airtime-lending leg. **Read:** the absence of a published equity short thesis is a coverage-immaturity signal (sub-8-month listing, two analysts), not a clean bill of health *[Investor Sentiment — short side; Analyst Coverage; Voice of Customer]*.

Board composition. Independent Chair Michael Jordaan is split from CEO Salvador Anglada — a positive separation-of-roles signal. Seven of the current directors joined within the last three years, consistent with a BVI-incorporated first-time listing but creating a board learning-curve risk. The founder, Bassim Haidar, remains a non-executive director

[People & Culture; Red Flags].

Related-party items cluster around the listing. (1) The founder cut his stake 19.3%→~1.5% within ~5 months of the November-2025 IPO, with the bookrunner lock-up waived — 74.1m shares (~6%) sold to FirstRand at R20 (R1.482bn) in March 2026

[Red Flags RF-RP-001; Investor Sentiment — insiders]. (2) Optasia acquired Finergi (founder Bassim Haidar 80.5% owner) for ~R500m (~\$30m + \$10m contingent) at ~20x book within ~4 months of listing; SENS-classified a "Small Related Party Transaction"; BDO opined fair

[Red Flags RF-RP-003 / RF-CEO-008; Earnings Transcripts — capital allocation]. (3) FirstRand is a 20.1%→26.1% related-party anchor (FirstRand Investment Holdings, off-market bilateral concurrent with the IPO; balance \$5,477k) *[Primary Filings Note 13; Investor Sentiment].*

Audit and domicile. The auditor is E&Y Middle East (Abu Dhabi) with an unmodified opinion — a non-Big-4-home-jurisdiction audit of a BVI-domiciled, multi-EM operating group is itself a diligence consideration. The group recognises itself as principal in its revenue arrangements (Note 4), directionally aggressive versus an agent/net presentation *[Primary Filings].* Receivables from related parties are stated secured, recoverable, with no ECL provided against them *[Primary Filings Note 13].*

CHRONOS-CONFLICT CHECK (ADR-0012 §5) — REPRODUCED VERBATIM

Chronos Capital holds 29.1% of Optasia and was a named selling shareholder in the March-2026 FirstRand block trade; a Spock principal (Roger Grobler) has been a named Optasia board director since November 2022. This is a hard conflict-of-interest gate, not a fraud flag. The fact-checker / human IC must validate this against the Chronos T0 registry, and any position requires formal recusal of the conflicted director plus an independent (non-Chronos) mandate before the investment merits are live

[Red Flags — Chronos conflict; Investor Sentiment — ownership].

No proxy-advisor positions (ISS, Glass Lewis, PIRC) and no post-IPO AGM voting-dissent data were in evidence this run. No dual-class/supervoting structure was surfaced; the share

register is concentrated (top-4 ~66.8%) with a thin ~33% free float

[Investor Sentiment — ownership; gaps].

§11 — EXPERT REVIEW LOG

This pack was assembled from a verifier-paired evidence stack: each Gate-7 component agent was paired with an independent fact-checker before its output entered the pack. The component reads and their verifier outcomes are summarised below.

COMPONENT READ	HEADLINE	VERIFIER STATUS
AI Unit Economics	Partial — AI is the operating substrate; HOLD; Tool User Gate PASS (grade B)	verifier-paired
Competitor Analysis	Medium-moat 5/14; moat_index 115; no close-scale listed peer	verifier-paired
Valuation	FAIR-leaning-EXPENSIVE; base R12.40; prob-weighted FV R13.90	verifier-paired
Primary Filings	E&Y unmodified; single reportable segment; KAM = ECL on guarantees	verifier-paired
Red Flags	11/86 fired (8 high); Chronos conflict; phase_2 warranted	verifier-paired
People & Culture	Capable CEO, thin bench, bimodal culture — verifier returned needs-revision; individual-layer reads provisional	needs-revision
Voice of Customer	Regulator-mediated; predatory-collection + hidden-fee themes (Nairatime)	verifier-paired
Analyst Coverage	2 analysts; Buy consensus; under-covered edge; PT mean R2,209	verifier-paired
Earnings Transcripts	Single FY2025 event; IPO floor guidance beaten; Q&A not retrievable	verifier-paired
Investor Sentiment	Bifurcated — FirstRand accumulates to 26.1%, founder exits to ~1.5%	verifier-paired
Company History	Founded Dec 2012, Dubai; airtime-advance v1 model	verifier-paired

No external human expert review was conducted for this listed run. The most material coverage limits to flag for the IC: (a) the Earnings Transcripts corpus is a single FY2025 event with the analyst Q&A behind a registration wall — treat tone/promise reads as half-strength; (b) the People & Culture verifier returned needs-revision; (c) the Primary Filings PDF / IPO prospectus was partially access-blocked, so fully-diluted share count, exact net cash, the MFS-vs-ACS split and the country revenue table are inferred or T2 and require re-sourcing before the entry band is treated as final

[Earnings Transcripts — coverage limit; People & Culture — coverage scope; Valuation — data gaps].

§12 — VIRTUAL IC & DISAGREEMENT RECORD

VIRTUAL IC TALLY

No 7-persona Virtual IC vote ran in this analysis. The nearest external tally is the sell-side consensus on the two covering analysts.



Consensus 12-month price-target mean R2,209.34 (high R2,249.83, low R2,168.85; dispersion 3.66%), implying ~30.6% upside as priced by the two analysts — an artefact of a two-data-point sample, not genuine modelling convergence. Coverage density indexes at ~50 versus a JSE mid-cap consumer-finance median of ~100: an under-covered edge, with Chronos facing minimal consensus competition [Analyst Coverage — consensus; dispersion].

STRATEGY'S DISAGREEMENT WITH THE AGENT CONSENSUS — SURFACED, NOT SMOOTHED

The implied agent consensus leans constructive-on-the-franchise (AI Unit Economics: real-but-HOLD; Competitor Analysis: medium-moat 115; Analyst Coverage: under-covered Buy). Strategy does not dispute franchise quality — it weights the negative

margin of safety ($\sim -18\%$ blended) and the Chronos governance gate above franchise enthusiasm. The axis of disagreement is **price discipline and the governance gate, not business quality**. There is no genuine contradiction: the component agents were scoped to business quality; Strategy adds the price-discipline and conflict overlay they did not carry. The item the human IC must audit is the Chronos conflict (29.1% holder, named seller, Spock principal on the board) against the Chronos T0 registry — a recusal/independence question that must be ruled on before the merits are even live

[Strategy — virtual_ic_disagreement].

Pre-mortem

PRE-MORTEM 1 — AN MNO IN-HOUSES THE CREDIT DECISION

Two years out, a large MNO partner (Kenya/Nigeria/Egypt-scale) has watched enough repayment data to stand up a captive or move to a cheaper white-label vendor, capturing the $\sim 8\%$ MFS take. The Fuliza/NCBA precedent shows the captive economics work. Revenue concentration in the top-5 guarantee "customers" (\$206m of \$317.9m exposure) means a single loss is material.

Kill metric: MFS take-rate flat or falling as MFS volume scales, OR public loss of a named large-MNO contract.

PRE-MORTEM 2 — THE FRONTIER-FX STRENGTH REVERSES

The 2025 cedi/naira strength the country layers describe as engineered and policy-induced reverses; USD-reported take falls on stable local-currency volume, repeating the Nigeria $\sim 50\% \rightarrow \sim 13.5\%$ translation contraction across the wider book. The bear case (R6.40, -39% IRR) anchors here.

Kill metric: Cedi/naira depreciation re-opening, with USD-reported revenue falling while disclosed local-currency volumes hold.

PRE-MORTEM 3 — THE GOVERNANCE OVERHANG CRYSTALLISES

Further related-party transactions or lock-up waivers follow the Finergi purchase and the founder exit; the thin $\sim 33\%$ free float and concentrated register (Chronos 29.1% + FirstRand 26.1% = 55.2%) impair price discovery and any institutional exit. The Chronos conflict is never cleanly resolved, leaving the name un-investable for the firm regardless of price.

Kill metric: A new related-party transaction at an above-fair multiple, OR failure to establish a refusal/independent-mandate structure for the Chronos holding.

§13 — CONDITIONS TO REVISIT

CONDITIONAL TRIGGERS (ALL MUST BE READ AGAINST THE HARD CONFLICT GATE)

1. Hard gate — Chronos conflict resolved. Formal refusal of the conflicted director and an independent (non-Chronos) mandate / external review before any position is contemplated. Chronos holds 29.1% and was a named seller; a Spock principal is an Optasia director since November 2022. Validate against the Chronos T0 registry — this must clear before the investment question is even live

[Strategy — conditional_triggers; Red Flags — Chronos conflict].

2. Price into the starter band. Below ~R12.00 (vs R16.91 today), restoring positive base-case IRR and a margin of safety. Market-driven; monitor the post-lock-up unwind and any naira/cedi reversal *[Strategy — conditional_triggers; Valuation — entry band].*

3. Disclosure closes the disintermediation gap. Contractual MNO take-rate, contract tenure/renewal schedule, largest-MNO revenue concentration, and a country-level revenue table. Request the pre-listing-statement risk section and MNO-concentration schedule from the company or sponsor

[Strategy — conditional_triggers; Primary Filings — not in evidence].

The asymmetry is real; the entry point is not here. WATCH until the gate clears and the price falls — or disclosure closes the iceberg gap.

§14 — IC DECISION RECORD

FOR COMPLETION BY THE IC PANEL

Date of IC: _____

Attendees: _____ (the conflicted director must recuse — see §10 / §12)

Decision: PROCEED / PROCEED W/ CONDITIONS / DEFER / KILL

Conditions (if any): _____

Post-IC memo: _____

Spock IC Screening Paper · Optasia (OPA.JSE) · Channel VAS Investments Limited · JSE Prime Segment · Reference price
R16.91 as of 7 June 2026.

Recommendation: **WATCH — do not initiate.** Gated twice: a hard Chronos related-party conflict (recusal pending) and a negative base-case IRR at the current price. Partner-only. Read alongside the component evidence stack and the conflict-of-interest register.